312. These performances in Ireland gave me valuable confidence.

The telephone was ringing ... again.

This time, during a pivotal period of my career, Dave Nosworthy told me to travel home immediately because Ray Jennings wanted me to join the South Africa A team tour to Zimbabwe. I said a rushed farewell to Barry and my teammates in Carrick and flew from Belfast to London to Harare and then on to Bulawayo, where I joined an A team squad that included the likes of captain Ashwell Prince, Albie Morkel, Hashim Amla, Neil McKenzie and Paul Adams.

Ray Jennings was a hardcore coach, and I enjoyed the way he challenged us. One of the finest wicketkeepers ever produced by South Africa and a key member of the great 'Mean Machine' Transvaal team of the 1980s, he left no one in any doubt that he wanted players to be tough in everything they did and to show some guts in tough times. Ray used to wield the bat during endless fielding drills, literally smashing the ball at our shins and expecting us to get something – anything – in the way. It didn't matter to him as long as the ball was stopped. I dared not flinch. Some players said the coach was crazy, but I loved every minute.

The first unofficial Test at Queens Club went well. Replying to Zimbabwe A's 186 in the first innings, I contributed 91 to our first-innings total of 307. Eventually set 168 to win, I managed to score 84 as we eased to victory by seven wickets.

A second unofficial Test started three days later at the same venue and, after Albie Morkel and Neil McKenzie scored runs, we pushed hard for a second win – but, as you would expect, the Zimbabweans fought hard, and had two wickets standing when the match ended in a draw.

I was pleased. Things had gone well. I was up, but I was soon down again when I was left out of the A team to play three one-day matches against Zimbabwe A. My prospects suddenly seemed uncertain. To some, it seemed, I was a talented young dasher who lacked the patience and technique to be consistently successful at the highest level.